

32 Miriam

The prophetess who led Israel's women in song beside the sea.

Miriam was the sister of Moses and Aaron and the first woman in the Bible called a prophetess. Most readers take her to be the unnamed sister who watched over baby Moses on the Nile and boldly offered to find a nurse for him. After the crossing of the sea, she took a timbrel and led the women of Israel in dancing and praise. Micah later names her with her brothers as one of the three leaders God sent to Israel. But Miriam also spoke against Moses, and God struck her with leprosy for seven days. She died at Kadesh before Israel entered the land. Her life joins courage, worship and leadership with a sobering warning about envy.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Miryam</i> . Its meaning is uncertain; many suggestions have been made
Family	Daughter of Amram and Jochebed; sister of Aaron and Moses (Numbers 26:59; 1 Chronicles 6:3)
Role	Prophetess and leader of worship (Exodus 15:20; Micah 6:4)
When	From Moses' birth, c. 1526 BC, to the wilderness years, on the early date
Key places	The Nile, the shore of the Red Sea, Hazeroth, Kadesh
Main passages	Exodus 2:4–8; 15:20–21; Numbers 12:1–15; 20:1
New Testament	Not named

"And Miriam answered them, Sing ye to the LORD, for he hath triumphed gloriously; the horse and his rider hath he thrown into the sea."

Exodus 15:21, KJV

The life of Miriam

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. Exodus 2 does not name Moses' sister, but Miriam is the only sister Scripture gives him.

- c. 1526 BC

●

Watches over her brother

She stands at a distance to see what will happen to the baby in the basket. When Pharaoh's daughter finds him, she offers to call a Hebrew nurse and brings their mother. *Exodus 2:4-8*
- c. 1446 BC

●

Leads the song

After Israel crosses the sea, "Miriam the prophetess, the sister of Aaron" takes a timbrel. All the women follow her with timbrels and dances as she sings. *Exodus 15:20-21*
- c. 1445 BC

Hazereth

●

Speaks against Moses

She and Aaron criticize Moses because of his Cushite wife and ask whether God speaks only through him. God calls the three to the tabernacle and rebukes her and Aaron. *Numbers 11:35; 12:1-9*
- c. 1445 BC

Hazereth

●

Struck and healed

She becomes leprous, "white as snow." Moses cries out, "Heal her now, O God." She is shut outside the camp for seven days, and the people wait for her. *Numbers 12:10-16*
- c. 1406 BC

Probably the fortieth year

●

Dies at Kadesh

Israel comes to the wilderness of Zin in the first month. Miriam dies at Kadesh and is buried there. *Numbers 20:1*

Group notes

Key activities

The year of Miriam's death is not stated. Numbers 20:1 names only "the first month," but it comes just before Aaron's death in the fortieth year, so most scholars place it in that year.

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- 1 **Kept watch.** As a girl she watched over her baby brother in the reeds. *Exodus 2:4*
 - 2 **Spoke up at the right moment.** She asked Pharaoh's daughter, "Shall I go and call to thee a nurse of the Hebrew women?" *Exodus 2:7-8*
 - 3 **Led worship.** She led the women in praise with timbrels and dancing after the sea crossing. *Exodus 15:20-21*
 - 4 **Served as a leader.** God said he sent "Moses, Aaron, and Miriam" before his people. *Micah 6:4*
 - 5 **Spoke against Moses.** She and Aaron questioned his marriage and his unique standing. She is named first, and she alone is punished. *Numbers 12:1-10*
 - 6 **Was restored.** After seven days outside the camp she was brought back in, and Israel did not move on until she returned. *Numbers 12:14-15*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Miriam.

Old Testament

Exodus 2:4–8	The unnamed sister, usually taken to be Miriam
Exodus 15:20–21	She leads the women in the song of victory
Numbers 12:1–15	She speaks against Moses and is struck with leprosy
Numbers 20:1; 26:59	Her death at Kadesh; her place in the family
Deuteronomy 24:9	"Remember what the LORD thy God did unto Miriam"
Micah 6:4	Sent with Moses and Aaron to lead Israel
1 Chronicles 4:17	A different Miriam, of Judah

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:46–55	Mary sings of God's triumph over the proud
Echo: Revelation 15:2–3	The redeemed sing "the song of Moses"
Echo: James 3:5–10	A warning about the tongue

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Miriam do at the sea, and who followed her (Exodus 15:20–21)?
2. *Understand:* Numbers 12 mentions Moses' wife, but God's answer is about Moses' role. What do you think the real issue was?
3. *Apply:* Miriam spoke up to protect her brother. When might you need to speak up for someone this week?
4. *Apply:* Is there someone whose role or gifts you are tempted to resent? What would it look like to honor them instead?